



NEW WESTMINSTER



CHILD CARE NEEDS ASSESSMENT

Fall 2015



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Executive Summary

In 2008, the City of New Westminster completed a *Child Care Needs Assessment*. At this time, national, provincial and local newspapers featured articles about the lack of child care and its impacts on children, families, employers and municipalities. In response, City Council voiced its desire to be a municipal leader in the area of child care and developed a *Child Care Strategy*, which contained 21 actions in support of a comprehensive child care system.

It has been seven years since the completion of the assessment and six years since the implementation of the strategy. During this time, there have been changes in the types of child care; shifts in senior government funding priorities related to child care; increasing activity on behalf of municipalities in facilitating child care; and a provincial campaign in support of a public system of integrated early care and learning.

In 2014, the City conducted research and consultation in support of a new assessment. This consultation involved 396 parents and 41 child care operators. The Kids New West Child Care Action Team informed the development of the assessment, with this document being written during the spring and summer of 2015.

Between 2008 and 2014, there has been a significant increase in the number of child care spaces in New Westminster. More specifically, there has been an increase of 493 child care spaces, which translates to a 41.2% increase in six years. Of note, an additional 123 child care spaces became operational by June 2015. Based on the number of child care spaces per 100 children aged 0 to 12 years in New Westminster, there were 16.3 child care spaces in 2008 and 22.0 child care spaces in 2014. As such, the number of child care spaces increased at a faster rate than the number of children 0 to 12 years.

Much of the net increase in child care spaces during the above cited period can be attributed to direct City actions, including rezoning applications and development variance permits (in which required off-street parking was converted to outdoor play space), the creation of civic child care spaces, the provision of child care grants and reserve funds, and the relaxation of zoning regulations, as well as a joint City and School District initiative which saw the creation of two neighbourhood learning centres anchored by licensed child care.

The City is now considered a municipal leader in the area of child care and is frequently asked to present at child care and early learning conferences. The City was also the recipient of several major awards, including the 2012 Provincial Child Care Award of Excellence and the 2013 Planning Institute of British Columbia Award of Excellence for Planning Practice.



Executive Summary

Despite the significant increase in child care spaces and the recognition received, the City, as documented in this assessment, still faces a number of significant challenges which will need to be addressed in the new strategy. These challenges include:

- The cost of child care, which, according to parent survey respondents, consumed, on average, 15.5% of total household income. For parent survey respondents receiving a child care subsidy, 57.9% reported that it was insufficient to bridge the difference between their ability to pay and the actual cost of their child care arrangements.
- The lack of infant/toddler care (0 to 36 months) and the reluctance on behalf of child care operators to provide this care type. Reasons cited include: high staff to child ratios (i.e., 1:4), increased indoor space (e.g., nap area), more stringent Building Code requirements and the need for separate play areas with developmentally appropriate equipment.
- The limited number of child care operators offering flexible child care arrangements or non-traditional hours. For parents who work evenings, nights, statutory holidays or weekends, or who require drop-in, emergency or part-time care, there are few, if any, options.
- The limited supply of child care in Queensborough, despite the fact that this sub-area is experiencing significant population growth, particularly by families with younger children. As evidence, the West End sub-area had 34.0 child care spaces per 100 children 0 to 12 years, while the Queensborough sub-area had 8.7 child care spaces per 100 children 0 to 12 years.

To continue to make progress in addressing these and other challenges, the City will have to be resourceful and capitalize on opportunities, both internally and externally. It will also require the support of the senior levels of government both with regard to creating and funding new child care spaces and in addressing the affordability crisis faced by increasing numbers of families.



Section 1: Introduction

This report provides an overview of the child care system and a snapshot of the current child care situation within New Westminster. More specifically, it defines what is meant by child care and describes the different types; details its importance for children, families and municipalities, including from a social and economic perspective; discusses how it is provided and funded and outlines the City's current role; examines the existing child care situation, including supply and demand factors; and identifies and analyzes a number of related issues.

The information gathering and consultation took place primarily in 2014. Where possible, the most current information is used, including 2011 Census and 2011 National Household Survey data. The Ministry of Children and Family Development and the YMCA Child Care Resource and Referral also provided information and feedback. The consultation is extensively based on two surveys, which involved 396 parents and 41 child care operators.

The purposes of the overview and snapshot are many and include:

- to consolidate child care information into one source in order to make it easier to access and use;
- to make a strong case for investing in child care from both a social and an economic perspective;
- to document trends, gaps and needs, including by sub-area;
- to identify issues that need to be addressed; and
- to inform the development of the City's new *Child Care Strategy*.

As with any overview and snapshot, it quickly becomes out-of-date. To ensure its currency and reliability, the KIDS New West Child Care Action Team, with the assistance of the City's Senior Social Planner, will periodically review and update the assessment information; prepare an annual report on progress in addressing gaps, needs and issues; and work to raise public awareness about the importance of and need for child care.



Section 2: Background

In 2008, New Westminster City Council voiced its desire to be a municipal leader in the area of child care. To this end, the City conducted a *Child Care Needs Assessment* (October 2008) and a *Child Care Strategy* (February 2009). The assessment was based on a survey of 428 parents, which represented the child care needs of 732 children, and 34 child care operators. The strategy, which was implemented over a three-year period, included 21 actions in support of a comprehensive child care system.

To help ensure strategy implementation, the City designated a staff person for this purpose. This person was also responsible for fielding all inquiries, informing land use planning, coordinating rezoning applications, facilitating partnerships and realizing funding opportunities related to child care. Additionally, the Kids New West Child Care Action Team was assigned the responsibility of monitoring and reporting on progress towards strategy implementation.

Since the development of the assessment, the City has realized over 600 new child care spaces and was the recipient of several major awards, including the 2012 Provincial Child Care Award of Excellence and the 2013 Planning Institute of British Columbia Award of Excellence for Planning Practice. The City is now considered a municipal leader in the area of child care in British Columbia and has been asked to present at a number of major conferences.

In 2014, the City, with the assistance of the Child Care Action Team, commenced work on a new assessment, which will inform child care planning and be instrumental in the development of a new strategy. This assessment is the third completed by the City and incorporates more statistical information related to supply and demand considerations, which was requested by child care operators who completed the most recent survey.

This assessment and the new strategy, when developed, will enable the City to better meet the needs of both parents and children who require child care, while continuing to position the City as a municipal leader in the area of child care.



Section 3: Definition & Types

In British Columbia, there are two categories of child care: licensed and unlicensed (may also be known as license-not-required). By law, if a child care provider cares for more than two children or one sibling group of any age not related to them by blood or marriage, then they must be licensed, with the following exceptions:

- municipally funded and operated programs that are two hours or less each day;
- programs that offer specific outcomes (e.g., recreation or tutoring); and
- summer and day camps for children aged five years or older.





Section 3: Definition & Types

LICENSED CHILD CARE

Licensed child care programs must meet and comply with the *Community Care and Assisted Living Act* and the *Child Care Licensing Regulation*. The latter sets out health and safety requirements; the license application process; space, program and equipment standards; staff/child ratios; and staffing qualifications. Licensed child care programs are also subject to regular inspections. For these reasons and others, parent survey respondents indicated that they preferred licensed establishments.

Licensed child care types include the following:

Family Child Care is offered in a caregiver's own home and serves children from 0 to 12 years. The caregiver sets the hours; however, most provide full-day care. In some settings, part-time and flexible hours are available. The maximum number of children is seven, with different age requirements depending on if a child younger than 12 months is present or not. If yes, then there can be no more than three children younger than 48 months and, of those three children, no more than one child younger than 12 months. If no, then there can be no more than four children younger than 48 months and, of those four children, no more than two children younger than 24 months.

LICENSED CHILD CARE

In-Home and Multi-Age Child Care raises the maximum number of children from seven to eight; however, the licensee must be certified as an Early Childhood Educator. As with family child care, there are different age requirements depending on if a child younger than 12 months is present or not. If yes, then there can be no more than three children younger than 36 months and, of those three children, no more than one child younger than 12 months. If no, then there can be no more than three children younger than 36 months.

Group Child Care serves children either from 0 to 36 months (also known as infant/toddler care) or from 30 months to school age (also known as three to five care). Centres offer year-round, full-day care, typically opening between 7:00 and 8:00 a.m. and closing between 5:30 and 6:00 p.m. In some settings, part-time hours are available.

The maximum group size is 12 for children under 36 months, with a separate area designated for each group. The maximum group size is 25 for children over 30 months to school age, with not more than two children younger than 36 months in a single group.



Section 3: Definition & Types

LICENSED CHILD CARE

Preschool Care serves children from 30 months to school age. Some preschools provide separate sessions for children aged three to four years, while others serve mixed age groups. Preschools are part-day programs (i.e., four hours maximum) and some require that parents participate in the program. Most preschools operate on the school year (September to June).

The maximum group size is 20 children with a minimum staff/child ratio of one Early Childhood Educator for 10 children and one educator and one assistant for 20 children.

Out-of-School Care serves school age children who require care outside of regular school hours. Most provide care before and after school, while some provide care only after school. Centres provide full-day care on days when school is not in session and many offer full-day spring-break and summer programs.

The maximum group size is 20 if any child in Kindergarten or Grade 1 is present and 25 if no child in Kindergarten or Grade 1 is present. Regarding the former, the minimum staff/child ratio is one responsible adult for 10 or fewer children and two responsible adults for 11 to 20 children. As for the latter, the minimum staff/child ratio is one responsible adult for 15 or fewer children and two responsible adults for 16 to 25 children. A responsible adult is 19 years of age or older and has completed a course, or a combination of courses, of at least 20 hours duration in child development, guidance, health, nutrition, or safety.

LICENSED CHILD CARE

Occasional Child Care provides occasional or short-term care to pre-school aged children who are at least 18 months and to each child for no more than 40 hours in a calendar month. The maximum number of children is 16 if any child present is younger than 36 months and 20 if no child present is younger than 36 months.





Section 3: Definition & Types

UNLICENSED CARE

License-Not-Required (LNR) Child Care is care offered by a child care provider in their own home. Care may only be offered for two children or one sibling group of any age that are not related to the provider by blood or marriage.

Registered License-Not-Required (RLNR) Child Care is care offered by a child care provider in their own home. Care may only be offered for two children or one sibling group of any age that are not related to the provider by blood or marriage. A child care provider who is registered has met health and safety requirements and must continue to meet all requirements with their local Child Care Resource and Referral program. Being registered also means that families attending the program may be eligible to receive an enhanced subsidy rate which is higher than for License-Not-Required child care establishments.

UNLICENSED CARE

In Child's Own Home Care is where a parent arranges for someone to look after their child or children in their home. An in-own home care provider may be called a 'nanny,' an 'au pair' or a 'babysitter.' The parent may hire an in-own home care provider directly or use a nanny agency.

A parent using in-own home care is considered to be an employer and must make both Canada Pension Plan and Employment Insurance payments and should contact both Canada Revenue Agency and the Workers' Compensation Board to find out about their obligations as an employer.





Section 4: Importance

Accessible, affordable and quality child care provides significant benefits for children, families and municipalities. Some of these benefits are documented in chart 1 and are highlighted in the following analysis.



Childcare Resource Unit, U of T, Martha Friendly.



Section 4: Importance

CHILDREN

Quality child care offers opportunities for children to develop in all areas of child development. Children have opportunities to learn how to get along with others and to learn new skills in a safe and nurturing setting. These positive childhood experiences have been found to enhance school readiness and later school success.

Child care facilitates higher family incomes, which directly benefits children, as it contributes to improved health and nutrition and affords opportunities to engage in extra-curricular

FAMILIES

activities.

Child care offers opportunities for parents to learn about different developmental and parenting issues. Together, parents and qualified child care staff can address concerns about challenges that may arise during a child's development in order that interventions can be incorporated.

Child care offers opportunities for parents to develop strong social support networks with other parents. These networks reduce social isolation, especially for single parents, and are often used to secure informal care and information outside of regular child care hours.

Child care is particularly beneficial to low-income and single parents as the ability to work can mean the difference between living on income assistance (welfare) and rising above the poverty

Learning takes place in all stages of life, and the biggest impact happens early in life. While it is well acknowledged that primary, secondary and post-secondary schooling develops and enhances key life skills and abilities, the learning that occurs during the first few years of life can have important, long-lasting effects that are often underestimated.

TD Economics, Early Childhood Education has Widespread and Long Lasting Benefits, Nov 27, 2012



Section 4: Importance

MUNICIPALITIES

line.

Social Considerations

Child care reduces differences in developmental vulnerability across neighbourhoods, when taking into account parental education and style, family income, and neighbourhood socio-economic characteristics.

Child care contributes to women's equality. By facilitating increased participation in the labour force, it contributes to income equality, financial security and social supports; all of which positively influence women's health and wellbeing.

Child care assists in the settlement and integration process for recent immigrants and refugees, as it offers opportunities for language learning and cultural integration for children and parents alike. It also offers opportunities for parents to build social support networks with other parents, including parents who are well

More than two-thirds of Canadian women with children under the age of five are in the workforce. And Canada needs them to be there, as the country expects to have a million job vacancies in the near future. Since women now account for 61% of post-secondary graduates, filling those gaps in skilled labour will depend on finding a way to keep those women working.

Erin Anderssen, The Case for Publicly Funded Child Care in Canada, The Globe and Mail, October 20, 2013



Section 4: Importance

MUNICIPALITIES

connected within the community.

Economic Considerations

Child care is an important consideration in attracting and retaining women within the labour force. Given the aging of the population and looming labour shortages in Canada, female participation in the labour force will become increasingly important. In 2012, 73.5% of Canadian women with children under 6 years were employed and 84.0% of Canadian women with children 6 to 15 years were employed.¹

Child care creates green jobs that do not harm the environment. The majority of child care dollars are invested in people and are spent locally, since the sector is labour intensive. Based on a Manitoba study, it found that every dollar of child care spending produces a ripple effect of

MUNICIPALITIES

\$1.58 in the local economy.²

Child care is essential to attracting families with young children, as many families are reliant on two incomes to afford today's housing. It is also essential to attracting and retaining businesses, as it positively impacts worker productivity. In a Health Canada study, which examined the costs of work-life conflict in Canada (January 2009), it was found that employers reported that the availability of early childhood development programs, including child care, was critical to the recruitment and retention of their parent employees. It was also found to reduce worker absenteeism and stress among parent employees; two factors which negatively impact worker productivity.

When you're an employer and you have A-list employees that don't return to work after maternity leave because they cannot afford to find child care, then this affects the productivity of our workplace. It is a business issue for the nation, especially as we are facing such extensive labour and skill shortages by the year 2020.

Anita Huberman, Surrey Board of Trade, 2014

¹ Canadian Child Care Federation, *Child Care: A Canadian Snapshot*, 2013.

² J. Wehner, B. Kelly and S. Prentice, *Rural and Northern Child Care: A Summary of Economic and Social Evidence from Manitoba*, Women's Working Group, Rural Secretariat, 2008.



Section 5: Provision & Funding

The Federal and Provincial governments are primarily responsible for child care in Canada; however, their combined investment in this area has not kept pace with demand. As a result, many children find themselves in unlicensed child care arrangements and fees have risen by almost double the rate of inflation over the past decade.³

In 2012, an Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) study found that Canada's public spending on early childhood education and care was between 0.2% and 0.34% of Gross Domestic Product (GDP), which was half the OECD average and only one-third of the recommended minimum one-percent for children 0 to 5 years. It should be noted that Quebec's public spending on child care skewed these figures, as this province's spending accounted for about 60% of the total.⁴

In 2012, the Canadian Child Care Federation reported that the percentage of children aged 0 to 5 years with mothers in the labour force was 73.5% and the percentage of children aged 0 to 5 years for whom there was a licensed or regulated child care space was 22.5%.⁵

The above cited OECD study also found that Canadian families with two working parents pay, on average, the fifth highest fees of the 30 industrialized countries – the equivalent of 18% of their net income. For low-income, single-parent families, it is worse, as they pay, on average, 48% of their net income.⁶

3 Tara Carman, 'Cost of Care for Children under 5 Exceeds University Tuition for some Metro Vancouver Families,' *Vancouver Sun*, July 18, 2014.

4 David Macdonald and Martha Friendly, *The Parent Trap: Child Care Fees in Canada's Big Cities*, Canadian Centre for Policy Alternatives, November 2014.

5 Canadian Child Care Federation, *Child Care: A Canadian Snapshot*, 2013.

6 Erin Anderssen, 'The Case for Publicly Funded Child Care in Canada,' *The Globe and Mail*, October 20, 2013.



Section 5: Provision & Funding

FEDERAL GOVERNMENT

The Federal government supports child care through direct support and tax measures and through the Canada Social Transfer to provinces and territories. Regarding the latter funds, provincial and territorial governments have the responsibility for the design and delivery of their programs.

Child Care Expense Deduction

The Child Care Expense Deduction allows child care expenses to be deducted from income when those expenses are incurred to earn employment or business income, pursue education or perform research. Currently, the maximum dollar limit is \$7,000 per child under 7 years, \$4,000 per child aged 7 to 16 years and \$10,000 per child who is eligible for the Disability Tax Credit, regardless of age. The Federal government, starting in 2015, is proposing to increase the maximum dollar limit by \$1,000 for each of the above tax deductible categories.

Universal Child Care Benefit

In 2006, the Federal government introduced the Universal Child Care Benefit, which provides all families \$100 per month for each child under the age of 6 years. Under Canada's Economic Action Plan, the Federal government is proposing, starting in 2015, to increase this benefit for children under 6 years (to \$160 per month) and expand the benefit to children aged 6 to 17 years (\$60 per month).

PROVINCIAL GOVERNMENT

The Provincial government provides financial support to child care in the following ways:

- Child Care Operating Funding Program
- Child Care Capital Funding Program
- Child Care Referral and Resource Program
- Child Care Subsidy and Special Needs Supplement
- *BC Early Years Strategy* and Provincial Office of the Early Years

Child Care Operating Funding Program

The Child Care Operating Funding Program assists eligible licensed group and family child care providers with the cost of providing child care. Funding amounts are based on enrollment and are available for all licensed care types, with the exception of occasional child care, child minding and residential care.

Child Care Licensing Regulation

The Child Care Licensing Regulation defines the various types of child care and prescribes licensing, facility, manager and employee requirements, as well as general care requirements.



Section 5: Provision & Funding

PROVINCIAL GOVERNMENT

Child Care Capital Funding Program

The Minor Capital Funding program assists licensed group child care facilities to maintain quality services. Under this program, facilities are eligible to receive up to \$2,000 for:

- emergency upgrades or repairs to existing facilities;
- emergency replacement of furnishings and equipment necessary to comply with the *Child Care Licensing Regulation*; and
- relocation costs when a child care facility is moving to another location.

There have been two recent intakes for the Major Capital Funding program, which is intended to assist with the costs associated with the creation of new licensed child care spaces. Under this program, non-profit child care organizations are eligible to receive up to a maximum of \$500,000 and for-profit child care organizations are eligible to receive up to a maximum of \$250,000 for:

- building a new child care facility, including the cost of buying land or a building;
- assembly of a modular building and site development;
- renovations to a building; and
- buying furnishings and equipment to support new child care spaces in an existing facility or as part of the above activities to create new spaces.

PROVINCIAL GOVERNMENT

Child Care Resource and Referral Program

The Child Care Resource and Referral Program provides services to child care providers and support, resources and referral for parents in municipalities across British Columbia.

Services to child care providers include:

- start-up, licensing and operating information;
- workshops, networking opportunities and referrals to community resources;
- access to child care resources such as equipment, library materials and toys; and
- a listing in a registry of child care providers, which is available to parents.

Services to parents include:

- referrals to local child care providers and other child care services;
- information on the types of child care available in the community;
- information on the Child Care Subsidy and Special Needs Supplement; and
- access to parent education opportunities such as printed information and workshops.



Section 5: Provision & Funding

PROVINCIAL GOVERNMENT

Child Care Subsidy and Special Needs Supplement

The Child Care Subsidy is a monthly payment to assist eligible parents with the cost of child care, with subsidy payments varying on a family's financial circumstances. Eligible parents who have a child designated with special needs and who requires child care, may also be eligible to receive a Special Needs Supplement. This supplement provides up to an additional \$150 per month towards the cost of child care.

In 2014/15, 543 children (441 families) were in receipt of a full or partial Child Care Subsidy and 45 children (43 families) were in receipt of a Special Needs Supplement in New Westminster (figure #1). It should be noted that the full subsidy does not cover the entire cost of child care.



Figure #1

Subsidy or Supplement*	2013/14		2014/15	
	Children	Families	Children	Families
Full Child Care Subsidy	377	299	345	281
Partial Child Care Subsidy	208	171	198	160
Special Needs Supplement	32	30	45	43
Total	486	377	432	344

*Since a child (family) can receive a full and partial subsidy and a special needs supplement at the same time, the sum of the counts of children (families) receiving a full or partial subsidy and a special needs supplement does not equal the total number of children (families) receiving a subsidy or supplement.



Section 5: Provision & Funding

PROVINCIAL GOVERNMENT

BC Early Years Strategy and Provincial Office of the Early Years

In 2013, the Provincial government released the *BC Early Years Strategy*, which is designed to improve access, affordability and quality of early years programs, including child care, as well as enhance coordination of government and community programs.

In early-2014, the Provincial Office of the Early Years was established with the purpose of overseeing the implementation of the strategy and facilitating coordination. As part of its mandate, it will establish a network of early years centres across British Columbia. To date, 26 community organizations have been selected to host such centres which will provide families with one-stop access to a range of services and supports.

In May 2014, the BC Early Childhood Educator Bursary was developed to increase the number of early childhood educators and in April 2015, the BC Early Childhood Tax Benefit will come into effect. This benefit will provide eligible families with a tax-free monthly payment of up to a maximum of \$55 per month for each child under the age of 6 years.





Section 5: Provision & Funding

MUNICIPAL GOVERNMENT

While the senior levels of government are primarily responsible for child care, many municipalities, in response to the growing demand and need, have become more active in this area.

Municipal responses include but are not limited to:

- preparing child care needs assessments and strategies;
- creating child care reserve funds and grant programs;
- establishing child care committees or participating on community bodies;
- designating staff to field child care inquiries;
- preparing step-by-step guides and other resource materials;
- providing nominal lease rates for non-profit child care providers in civic facilities;
- using density bonusing and other tools to realize civic child care facilities; and
- using permissive zoning to facilitate child care.

It should be recognized that municipalities have limited resources and taxation powers. They are also concerned about downloading by the senior levels of government.⁷

PUBLIC-SYSTEM

The Coalition of Child Care Advocates of BC and Early Childhood Educators of BC have launched a campaign in support of their *Community Plan for a Public System of Integrated Early Care and Learning*. This plan calls for affordable parent fees, an early years centre network and a new home for child care in the BC Ministry of Education. Regarding fees, it is proposed that they be capped at \$10.00 per day for full-time care and \$7.00 per day for part-time care, with no user fee for families with an annual income of less than \$40,000.⁸ The City of New Westminster, along with three regional districts and over 25 other municipalities in British Columbia, have endorsed the plan.

⁷ Downloading (or offloading) is defined as “the range of ways that federal and provincial governments pass administrative costs, capital costs, service provision and other expenses and responsibilities to local levels of government without adequate funding or revenue streams” (Charley Beresford, Robert Duffy and Gaetan Royer, ‘How Downloaded Costs are Steamrolling Local Governments,’ *The Tyee*, September 24, 2014).

⁸ Coalition of Child Care Advocates of BC and Early Childhood Educators of BC, *Community Plan for a Public System of Integrated Early Care and Learning*, Fall 2014. September 24, 2014).



Section 6: Existing Policy & Practice

The City of New Westminster, based on the implementation of the actions as contained in the *Child Care Strategy* (February 2009), has created a strong foundation on which to build future actions. In fact, child care is now designated as a standard community need similar to parkland and is integrated into the municipal planning process. Child care is also a consideration in all civic and development projects.

Official Community Plan

New Westminster's *Official Community Plan* (Bylaw 7435, 2011) states that the City should:

- encourage the provision of child care as an essential community-based service;
- promote child care within the City by facilitating partnerships with the community; and
- consider the provision of child care in the context of neighbourhood planning by evaluating the need for child care in proposed developments.

The City has been facilitating child care and early and middle childhood development in the following ways:

Policy Initiatives

- The City developed a *Child Care Needs Assessment* (October 2008), which was based on an extensive consultation process, including a survey of 428 parents.
- The City developed a *Child Care Strategy* (February 2009), which included 21 actions in support of a comprehensive child care system.
- The City's Council endorsed the *New Westminster Children's Charter* (2010), which is based on the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child.
- The City and the Society for Children and Youth of BC are developing a *Child and Youth Friendly Community Strategy*, which will inform the future design and development of the city and help ensure that neighbourhoods better meet the needs of families.

A comprehensive child care system is one that includes the provision of quality programs that are accessible and affordable.

New Westminster Child Care Strategy, 2009



Section 6: Existing Policy & Practice

Direct City Support

- The City designated a senior staff person to implement the strategy; to build partnerships; to field child care inquiries; to inform land use planning and coordinate rezonings related to child care; and to lobby the senior levels of government.
- The City created a Child Care Reserve Fund to assist with the capital cost of developing new civic child care facilities and partnering with government agencies and non-profit operators. This fund receives 10% of all density bonusing revenues.
- The City established a Civic Child Care Grant Program, which provides eight grants of up to \$5,000 annually to non-profit child care operators to address building deficiencies and purchase needed equipment and furnishings to meet provincial licensing requirements. Since its inception in 2010, \$147,898 has been granted.
- The City offers long-term, low-rate lease of space to the Kolumbia Inn Daycare Society at Queensborough Community Centre and the Queen's Park Preschool Society at Centennial Lodge.
- The City provides fee-based child minding and tiny tot playtime programs through its Parks, Culture and Recreation Department.⁹

The vast majority of respondents (75.8%), who answered a question about the quality of child care assistance received from City staff, rated it as very good (51.7%) or good (24.1%).

Child Care Operator Survey Results, 2014

⁹ Child minding is offered at Centennial Community Centre and four tiny tot playtimes targeting children between the ages of three and five are also offered by Parks, Culture and Recreation. The latter are a recreationally-based pre-school program.



Section 6: Existing Policy & Practice

Regulatory Initiatives

- The City uses Comprehensive Development zoning and Heritage Revitalization Agreements to facilitate the development of group child care facilities in Single Detached Dwelling Districts. To date, 153 child care spaces have been created through these regulatory tools.
- The City permits group child cares in all Commercial, Mixed Use and Multi-Family Residential Districts, subject to certain conditions being met.
- The City relaxed a number of zoning regulations related to child care. For example, it made it easier to develop child care facilities in multi-family residential buildings; it reduced off-street parking requirements for child care facilities in non-residential buildings; and it removed requirements related to minimum square footage of outdoor play space per child.¹⁰
- The City uses developer contributions to realize community amenities, including child care. Density bonusing enables an applicant to achieve additional floor space or more units per acre than permitted under existing zoning in exchange for community amenities.¹¹
- The City uses development variance permits to enable required off-street parking spaces for an existing commercial building to be converted to outdoor play space in order to meet provincial licensing requirements for child care operations in the Downtown. To date, 68 child care spaces have been created through this regulatory tool.

¹⁰ The requirement related to minimum square footage of outdoor play space per child was considered inflexible, as it did not take into consideration the possibility of alternating play times or using nearby park space. As such, it acted as an impediment to the development of child care.

¹¹ As part of the Larco development on the waterfront, the developer will provide a purpose-built group child care facility with between 36 and 44 spaces.



Section 6: Existing Policy & Practice

Partnerships

- The City is represented on the Public Partners Child Development Committee, the Kids New West Committee and the Child Care Action Team.¹² The Public Partners are mandated to support the development of five Child Development Hubs, each one of which will be anchored by licensed child care. To date, two hubs are operational, one is under development and two are in the planning stages.
- The City and School District #40 developed and signed a Child Care Protocol. The protocol contains seven key objectives, including maintaining and, where necessary, stabilizing existing child care spaces within their collective control, and planning for and developing new child care spaces on their collective lands.
- The City and School District #40 succeeded in realizing Neighbourhood Learning Centres (NLCs) at Ecole Qayqayt Elementary School and Ecole Fraser River Middle School.¹² Combined, the NLCs will contain 51 group and a minimum of 20 out-of-school child care spaces, as well as other child development and family-strengthening programs.

Advocacy Efforts

- The City's Council endorsed the *Community Plan for a Public System of Integrated Early Care and Learning*. This plan calls for affordable parent fees, an early years centre network and a new home for child care in the BC Ministry of Education.

¹² Includes the City of New Westminster, Fraser Health, the Ministry of Children and Family Development, School District #40 (New Westminster) and the United Way of the Lower Mainland.

¹³ Dedicated space within school facilities to meet community needs, including child development.



Section 7: Relation to Other Initiatives

This *Child Care Needs Assessment* and the new *Child Care Strategy*, when developed, will benefit from and inform a number of other initiatives related to families, children and youth in New Westminster.

Kids New West Committee

The Kids New West Committee is an amalgamation of the Early and Middle Childhood Development Committees. The committee's vision is *healthy, happy and resilient children and families engaged in an inclusive and supportive community*.

The committee is comprised of non-profit and public agency representatives who work collaboratively to build community capacity and maximize opportunities to support the wellbeing of children and their families. The committee has a number of sub-committees, including a Child Care Action Team. In recent years, the committee has prioritized and supported the development of child and family neighbourhood hubs, educational programming related to healthy child development, and family strengthening programs.

New Westminster Public Partners Child Development Committee

The New Westminster Public Partners Child Development Committee, which comprises the City of New Westminster, Fraser Health, the Ministry of Children and Family Development, School District #40 and the United Way of the Lower Mainland, was established in 2006. The committee's mandate is to establish five Child Development Hubs. These hubs, which will be anchored by licensed child care, will serve the Downtown, East End, Queensborough, Uptown and West End neighbourhoods. The committee signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) in support of hub development in 2007 and a revised MOU in 2011, with the latter expanding its mandate beyond early childhood to include both middle childhood and youth.



Section 7: Relation to Other Initiatives

Early and Middle Years Development Instruments

The Human Early Learning Partnership has completed five waves of research using the Early Development Instrument (EDI) and one wave of research using the Middle Years Development Instrument (MDI) in New Westminster.

The EDI and MDI are research tools, with the former assessing the state of a child's development in Kindergarten and the latter assessing the state of child's wellbeing in Grade 4. Both tools have similarities yet are based on different domains or dimensions (chart #2).

Each EDI domain is scored between 0 and 10. At the completion of the data collection, a provincial range of scores is established for each domain. The vulnerability threshold (or cut-off) is the EDI score that distinguishes the bottom 10% of children from the other 90%. Children who fall below that score are said to be vulnerable on that domain of development.

Based on wave 5 EDI results (2011/12 and 2012/13), New Westminster had a vulnerability

rate of 33% compared to a provincial vulnerability rate of 32.5%. Connaught Heights had the lowest level of vulnerability at 21% and Downtown-Stewardson had the highest level of vulnerability at 47%. District-wide, vulnerability was lowest on the Language and Cognitive domain at 10% and highest on the Social Competence domain at 16%.

The MDI is based on a development assets and strengths-based approach, which emphasizes protective factors that support and optimize development. The MDI Wellbeing Index is a composite score of all five dimensions. Based on MDI results for 2011/12 and 2012/13, in New Westminster, 49% of students were thriving, 23% had medium to high wellbeing and 28% had low wellbeing. Queen's Park had the highest percentage of students thriving at 60% and the Uptown had the lowest percentage of students thriving at 35%.

Licensed child care and after-school care and programming have been shown to reduce childhood vulnerability rates and increase wellbeing for middle years children.

Chart #2

EDI Domains	MDI Dimensions
Social Competence	Social and Emotional Development
Physical Health and Wellbeing	Physical Health and Wellbeing
Emotional Maturity	Connections to Adults and Peers
Language and Cognitive Development	School Experiences
Communication Skills and General Knowledge	Use of After-School Time



Section 7: Relation to Other Initiatives

Children's Charter

The New Westminster Early Childhood Development Committee, which was amalgamated with the Middle Childhood Development Committee to form the KIDS New West Committee, developed a New Westminster Children's Charter based on the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child. This charter is intended to raise awareness about the need to create healthy, inclusive, safe and supportive environments for children in order for them to participate in all facets of community life and to reach their full potential. Early childhood care and learning is an essential component to realizing this vision. In 2010, the City and School District endorsed the charter, which is recognized and celebrated each year during the National Day of the Child in November.

All children require high quality early childhood development opportunities and responsive primary and secondary education.

New Westminster Children's Charter, 2010





Section 7: Relation to Other Initiatives

Child Development Hubs

Five Child Development Hubs are planned for New Westminster. These hubs, which are anchored by licensed child care, act as focal points for their neighbourhoods and enable families to obtain information and seamlessly access a continuum of services related to their needs.

The first hub was developed as part of an expansion to the Queensborough Community Centre. It incorporates a licensed child care facility and tiny-tot playtime program and employs a service delivery approach which makes multi-purpose and flex-office space available to non-profit organizations offering child development and family strengthening programs.

The second hub, the Downtown Hub, is housed in a Neighbourhood Learning Centre (NLC) located at the Ecole Qayqayt Elementary School. It houses a licensed child care facility, an out-of-school care program, a multi-purpose room, flex office space and a community kitchen which is available to non-profit organizations and the public.

The third hub, the Uptown Hub, will be housed at a NLC located at the Ecole Fraser River Middle School, which will open in September 2016. It, too, will house a licensed child care facility and possibly an out-of-school care program, and will offer child development and family-strengthening programs.

Regarding the remaining two hubs, the East End and West End Hubs, needs assessment studies have been completed; however, sites have not been identified and funding has not been realized. Regarding the East End Hub, there is the possibility that it could form part of amenity contribution related to a large development project.



Section 7: Relation to Other Initiatives

Child and Youth Friendly Community Strategy

The *Child and Youth Friendly Community Strategy* is being developed by the City and the Society for Children and Youth of BC, with funding support from the United Way of the Lower Mainland and the Vancouver Foundation.

The strategy, which will be completed in November 2015, will inform the development of neighbourhoods which meet the needs of children, youth and families; provide opportunities for families to be an integral part of the municipal planning process; enhance family connections with their neighbourhoods and the larger community; and provide a range of housing choices, including housing with ground-orientation and three-plus bedroom counts.

The strategy incorporates eight domains; one of which is entitled *caring*. This domain includes the following vision: *children, youth and families have the necessary supports and access to a range of programs and services that meet their needs and promote wellbeing*. It also includes a number of actions, including those related to child care and hubs.





Section 7: Relation to Other Initiatives

Family-Friendly Housing Policy

The *Family-Friendly Housing Policy* forms part of the *Child and Youth Friendly Community Strategy*, and is intended to facilitate the provision of a range of housing choices for families, including housing with ground-orientation and three-plus bedroom counts.

Based on a housing analysis and a survey of 320 parents, in which 50.7% reported that their current housing situation somewhat or did not meet their family's needs, the evidence suggests that families, especially those with children reaching school age or anticipating the arrival of their second or third child, assess their housing situation and the ability of their neighbourhood to meet their needs. Given the lack of housing with ground-orientation and three-plus bedroom counts, as well as other issues such as housing affordability, increasing numbers of families with school age children are moving from or are choosing not to locate in New Westminster. In fact, there was a 4.3% decrease in children aged 6 to 12 between 2006 and 2011.

Based on the above cited research and consultation, as well as a feasibility study, the City developed a *Family-Friendly Housing Policy*, which was endorsed by Council. This policy requires new multi-family ownership projects to include a minimum of 30% two- and three-bedroom units and that at least 10% of the total project units be three-bedrooms or more. It also requires that new multi-family rental projects include a minimum of 25% two- and three-bedroom units and that at least 5% of the total project units be three-bedrooms or more.

This policy, by increasing the supply of family-friendly housing, will contribute to more families deciding to remain in or locate to New Westminster, which will increase the number of children aged 0 to 12 years and, correspondingly, increase the demand for licensed child care.



Section 8: Community Consultation

Community consultation was essential to the development of this *Child Care Needs Assessment* and will inform the development of the new *Child Care Strategy*. More specifically, it was a key in identifying needs and gaps, which will require targeted actions and new partnerships and resources to address.

Child Care Parent Survey

The child care parent survey was based on the previous survey, thus enabling comparisons between 2008 and 2014. For example, child care availability, with the exception of infant/toddler care, was less of an issue and affordability was more of an issue in the latter survey.

The survey was designed to gather information about the kinds of child care arrangements that are currently being used, the ease or difficulty in finding a placement, and the level of satisfaction with that placement, as well as suggestions to improve access to and increase the availability of child care. Respondents could complete the survey for more than one child.

The survey was widely distributed, with 1,280 copies available through child care, early learning and pre-school programs; 100 copies available through community, faith and social service organizations which serve at-risk and vulnerable families; and 175 copies available through civic facilities. Electronic survey links were also available through CityPage and three Mom's Facebook groups.

In total, 396 surveys were completed and returned, which represented a return rate of 25.5%. This is high return rate given the methodology employed and this speaks to the importance of child care for parents with children aged 0 to 12 years. These 396 surveys represented the child care needs of 595 children.





Section 8: Community Consultation

Regarding the above survey respondents, the City prepared a representativeness analysis to determine if certain groups were adequately represented. This analysis found that the following groups were equally represented in the parent survey in comparison to data from the 2011 Census and 2011 National Household Survey;

- Aboriginal parent respondents (4.1% vs. 3.4%);
- Parents who do not speak English at home respondents (19.7% vs. 19.1%);
- Single-parent household respondents (19.0% vs. 19.8%); and
- Downtown, East End, Glenbrook North, Queen's Park and Uptown respondents.

The following groups were underrepresented in the parent survey in comparison to data from the 2011 Census and 2011 National Household Survey;

- Recent immigrant parent respondents (3.5% vs. 7.0%);
- Renter household respondents (29.3% vs. 35.0%);
- Parents who lived in the city for less than five years respondents (27.5% vs. 32.7%); and
- Queensborough and West End respondents.

The parent survey results were augmented by additional information, including a focus group with parents of children with extra support needs and focus groups and surveys with low-income families and new immigrants. More specifically, consultation, including that related to child care, was undertaken with low-income families as part of the New Westminster Community Poverty Reduction Initiative and a survey of 224 new immigrants was conducted by the City's Multiculturalism Advisory Committee. Regarding the latter, 30.0% of new immigrant survey respondents reported having difficulty finding child care.



Section 8: Community Consultation

Child Care Operator Survey

The child care operator survey was based on the previous survey in order to facilitate comparisons and was distributed to all licensed child care facilities in New Westminster.

The survey was designed to gather information about the types of buildings in which the program is located, the building's ability to meet current and future program requirements, the building's tenure arrangements and their security, and the license type and the number of spaces provided, as well as suggestions to improve access to and increase the availability of child care.

In total, 41 surveys were completed, which represented 54.6% of all licensed child care facilities and 60.0% of all licensed child care programs. It also represented 66.6% of all licensed child care spaces in New Westminster.

The response rate by license type was over 60% with the exception of family child care homes (34.8%) and pre-school programs (25.0%). The response rate was over 50% by geographic sub-area with the exception of Glenbrook North and Queen's Park (40.0%).





Section 9: Current Child Care Situation

SUPPLY CONSIDERATIONS

As of November 2014, there were a total of 1,691 licensed child care spaces in New Westminster, with these spaces being located in 79 facilities and 101 child care programs.

The number of licensed child care spaces has increased significantly since 2008, which is the year in which the last assessment was completed. More specifically, there has been an increase of 493 child care spaces, which translates to a 41.2% increase over six years.

Based on the number of child care spaces per 100 children aged 0 to 12 years in New Westminster, there were 16.3 spaces in 2008 and 22.0 spaces in 2014 (figure #2). As such, the number of child care spaces increased at a faster rate than the number of children 0 to 12 years. Of note, this trend would appear to be continuing, as an additional 123 spaces will be operational by June 2015.

Figure #2

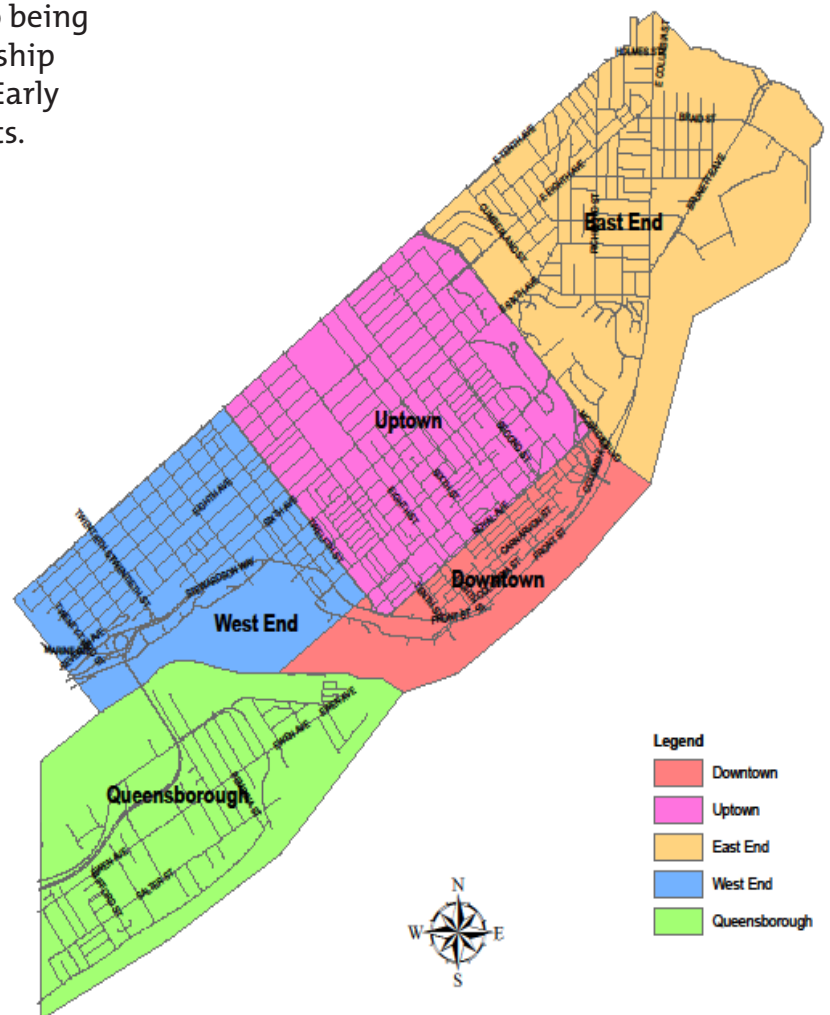
Year	Number of Child Care Spaces	Number of Children 0 to 12 Years	Number of Child Care Spaces per 100 Children 0 to 12 Years
2008	1,198	7,368	16.3
2010	1,350	7,567	17.8
2012	1,522	7,538	20.2
2014	1,691	7,696	22.0
Change 2008-2014	493	328	5.7



Section 9: Current Child Care Situation

SUPPLY CONSIDERATIONS

Within New Westminster, there are significant differences in the distribution of licensed child care spaces for each of the five sub-areas (map #1). Similar sub-areas are being used by the Public Partners and Kids New West Child Development Committees as part of their planning efforts, including related to the siting of five Child Development Hubs. They are also being used by the Human Early Learning Partnership with regard to the implementation of the Early and Middle Years Development Instruments.



Map #1



Section 9: Current Child Care Situation

SUPPLY CONSIDERATIONS

The Uptown sub-area had the most licensed child care spaces (593 or 35.1%) in 2014, followed by the West End, East End, Downtown and Queensborough sub-areas (figure #3). Of note, the Downtown and Queensborough sub-areas, which combined only had 307 or 18.2% of the total spaces, are experiencing significant population growth.

The West End and East End sub-areas had the largest increase in numbers of licensed child care spaces between 2008 and 2014 (173 and 136 respectively); however, the Downtown had the largest percentage increase (121.1%) (figure #4).

Figurer #3

Sub-Area	Family Daycare	In-Home Multi-Age	Group Under 36	Group 30-60 mo	Group Multi-Age	Group - Preschool	Group School Age	Total
Downtown	0	0	36	107	0	0	56	199
East End	21	0	80	89	16	16	163	385
Queensborough	14	24	0	50	0	0	20	108
Uptown	70	16	37	228	32	30	180	593
West End	42	8	20	100	24	60	152	406
Total	147	48	173	574	72	106	571	1,691

Figure #4

Sub-Area	2008	2014	Change, 2008-2014
Downtown	90	199	109
East End	240	385	136
Queensborough	59	108	49
Uptown	560	593	33
West End	233	406	173
Total	1,198	1,691	493



Section 9: Current Child Care Situation

SUPPLY CONSIDERATIONS

Regarding the number of licensed child care spaces per 100 children aged 0 to 12 years, there are also significant differences between sub-areas. The West End sub-area had 34.0 spaces per 100 children 0 to 12 years, while Queensborough had 8.7 spaces per 100 children aged 0 to 12 years. The Downtown (29.1), Uptown (22.5) and East End (21.5) fell within this range (figure #5).

Regarding licensed child care spaces by type, the vast majority (67.7%) were in group (30 to 60 months) and out-of-school care settings. More specifically, 574 or 33.9% of these spaces were in group (30 to 60 months) and 571 or 33.7% of these spaces were out-of-school care settings. A much smaller number and percentage of spaces (173 or 10.2%) were in group (0 to 36 months) settings.

As with the number of licensed child care spaces, there were significant differences with regard to the distribution of child care spaces by type and by sub-area (figures #6, #7, #8). As evidence,

SUPPLY CONSIDERATIONS

- the East End sub-area (16.5) had the highest number of group (0 to 36 months) spaces per 100 children 0 to 2 years and the Queensborough sub-area (0.0) had the lowest;
- the Downtown sub-area (82.3) had the highest number of group (30 to 60 months) spaces per 100 children 3 to 4 years and the Queensborough sub-area (25.6) had the lowest; and
- the West End sub-area (19.9) had the highest number of out-of-school care spaces per 100 children 5 to 12 years and the Queensborough sub-area (2.9) had the lowest.

By sub-area, Queensborough had the lowest number of group (both 0 to 36 months and 30 to 60 months) and out-of-school spaces per 100 children by appropriate age category. This would suggest that this sub-area had a significant under-supply of child care spaces.

Figure #5

Sub-Area	Number of Child Care Spaces (2014)	Number of Children 0-12 Years (2011)	Number of Child Care Spaces per 100 Children 0-12 Years
Downtown	199	685	29.1
East End	385	1,785	21.6
Queensborough	108	1,240	8.7
Uptown	593	2,630	22.5
West End	406	1,105	34.0



Section 9: Current Child Care Situation

Figure #6

Sub-Area	Number of Group Under 36 Months Spaces (2014)	Number of Children 0-2 Years (2011)	Number of Group Under 36 Months Spaces per 100 Children 0-2 Years
Downtown	36	285	12.6
East End	80	485	16.5
Queensborough	0	350	0.0
Uptown	37	660	5.6
West End	20	240	8.3

Figure #7

Sub-Area	Number of Group 30-60 Months Spaces (2014)	Number of Children 3-4 Years (2011)	Number of Group 30-60 Months Spaces per 100 Children 3-4 Years
Downtown	107	130	82.3
East End	89	295	30.2
Queensborough	50	195	25.6
Uptown	228	425	53.5
West End	100	190	52.6

Figure #8

Sub-Area	Number of Group Out-of-School Care Spaces (2014)	Number of Children 5-12 Years (2011)	Number of Group Out-of-School Care Spaces per 100 Children 5-12 Years
Downtown	56	270	20.7
East End	163	1,005	16.2
Queensborough	20	695	2.9
Uptown	180	1,545	11.7
West End	152	765	19.9



Section 9: Current Child Care Situation

DEMAND CONSIDERATIONS

Population Growth and the Number of Children Aged 0 to 12 Years

In order to understand demand for child care, it is important to examine characteristics of the local population and information on child care fees.

Between 2006 and 2011, New Westminster's population increased from 58,549 to 65,976 or by 12.7%. In 2014, the population is estimated to be close to 70,000. By 2021, the population is projected to increase to 79,061, and by 2031, the population is projected to increase to 92,098.

In 2011, the number of children 0 to 12 years was 7,696. Of this number, 2,018 were aged 0 to 2 years, 1,274 were aged 3 to 4 years and 4,404 were aged 5 to 12 years, which combined accounted for 11.7% of the total population. In the same year, the Uptown (2,630) had the highest and the Downtown (685) had the lowest number of children aged 0 to 12 years.

DEMAND CONSIDERATIONS

Between 2014 and 2024, the number of children aged 0 to 12 years is projected to increase from 7,696 to 9,564, with most of this growth occurring between 2014 and 2020. During this time period, the number of children 0 to 2 years is projected to increase from 2,018 to 2,251, the number of children 3 to 4 years is projected to increase from 1,274 to 1,476 and the number of children 5 to 12 years is projected to increase from 4,404 to 5,837.

If the current number of licensed child care spaces (22.0) per 100 children 0 to 12 years is achieved in 2024, then there will need to be a net increase of 410 spaces. Given that about a third of these spaces (123) will be operational by June 2015, then this number should not be too difficult to achieve.

The challenge in moving forward will be to continue to increase the number of licensed child care spaces per 100 children 0 to 12 years.



Section 9: Current Child Care Situation

DEMAND CONSIDERATIONS

The University of Guelph Child Care Resource Unit, in its *State of Child Care in Canada* report (2012), found that the number of licensed child care spaces per 100 children 0 to 12 years ranged from a high of 37.4 in Quebec to a low of 7.6 in Saskatchewan with British Columbia falling just north of the midway point at 18.0 but less than the Canadian average of 20.5, although the latter was skewed by Quebec, which offers a publicly-funded, universal child care program.

DEMAND CONSIDERATIONS

Metro Vancouver, as part of a survey on municipal child care provision (2011), found that the number of licensed child care spaces per 100 children 0 to 12 years ranged from a high of 22.9 in North Vancouver City to a low of 5.9 in Langley City, with New Westminister falling just north of the midway point at 18.3 and above the Metro Vancouver average of 16.0. Please note that this survey is currently being replicated but the results will not be available until after the completion of this assessment.

In moving forward, there will be a need to determine what number is needed to enable parents to locate a placement in a timely manner and to ensure that there is an adequate and equitable distribution of child care spaces by type and by sub-area in New Westminister. In the short-term, there will be a need to increase the number of group (0 to 36 months) spaces and the number of spaces for all child care types in the Queensborough sub-area.



Section 9: Current Child Care Situation

DEMAND CONSIDERATIONS

Participation in the Labour Force

In 2011, there were 5,035 women in the labour force with children 0 to 12 years in New Westminster. As such, the labour force participation rate for these women was 74.3%. Of this total, there were 1,990 women in the labour force with children under 6 years and 1,170 women in the labour force with children 6 to 12 years. For the former, the labour force participation rate was 70.1%, and for the latter, the labour force participation rate was 85.0%. In 2011, there were 520 women in the labour force who headed single parent families with children 0 to 12 years. As such, the labour force participation rate for these women was 79.4%.

The higher the percentage of women in the labour force with children 0 to 12 years, the greater the demand for all types of child care. Based on child care parent survey, a number of respondents commented that they had delayed returning to work after their maternity benefits had ended or had dropped out of the labour force due to a lack of available child care in New Westminster. In fact, 41.5% of respondents reported that the lack of suitable child care had limited their ability to work or to find work.

DEMAND CONSIDERATIONS

Cultural Diversity

Between 2006 and 2011, increases to the immigrant population comprised 61.3% of total population growth in New Westminster. In 2011, 33.4% of the population was comprised of immigrants, with 21.0% of immigrants having less than five years of Canadian residency. Between 2006 and 2011, the top five source countries for immigrants were: the Philippines (25.0%), China and Hong Kong (12.4%), India (6.3%), Romania (5.2%) and the United States (4.5%). In both 2010 and 2012, about 5.0% of Government Assisted Refugees entering British Columbia settled in New Westminster.

In 2011, 32.8% of the population reported a mother tongue other than English or French. Of this population, the top five mother tongues were: Cantonese or Mandarin (19.5%), Filipino or Tagalog (11.9%), Punjabi (11.8%), Spanish (5.1%) and Korean (4.8%). In 2011, 34.8% of the population reported visible minority status and 3.2 of the population reported Aboriginal identity.

Given increasing immigration and cultural diversity, there will be increasing demand for child care providers to be inclusive of different languages and more sensitive to cultural traditions. There will also be a need for the City, Fraser Health and the YMCA Child Care Resource and Referral to educate and inform immigrant groups about licensed child care, including how to access it and how to apply for a Child Care Subsidy and Special Needs Supplement.



Section 9: Current Child Care Situation

DEMAND CONSIDERATIONS

Family Composition

In 2011, 1,875 children and youth aged 0 to 17 years lived in single parent families, which represented 18.1% of all children and youth in New Westminster.

The Uptown sub-area, with 980 single parent families, had highest number of such families by sub-area in New Westminster, followed by the East End (580). Single parent families typically face a much higher risk of being low-income than two parent families. As evidence, in 2010, 40.2% of children and youth aged 0 to 17 years in single parent families were in low-income families, compared with 12.6% of their counterparts in two parent families.





Section 9: Current Child Care Situation

DEMAND CONSIDERATIONS

Family Incomes

In 2010, 1,780 children and youth aged 0 to 17 years lived in low-income families, which represented 17.2% of all children and youth in New Westminster. This percentage was slightly lower than the British Columbia and Metro Vancouver averages of 19.1% and 19.5% respectively.

Child care fees (figure #9 and #10) represent a significant monthly expense, especially when combined with the high housing costs in New Westminster. For low-income families, including those who are eligible for a Child Care Subsidy, these fees can be prohibitively expensive, which means that many of these families must forego work, which places them deeper into poverty, or utilize unlicensed, unregulated child care arrangements.

DEMAND CONSIDERATIONS

Based on child care parent survey, the reported percentage of household income which is allocated to meeting child care related costs averaged 15.5%; however, 17.3% of respondents allocated a quarter or more of their household income. Additionally, 15.5% of respondents reported that they were in receipt of a Child Care Subsidy, with 57.9% of them reporting that it is insufficient in making up the difference between their ability to pay and the cost of their current child care arrangements.

Figure #9*

Family Child Care Fees, 2014	Under 1	Toddler	30-60 Months	Out-of-School Care
Median Full-Time Cost/Month	\$800.00	\$750.00	\$650.00	\$300.00
Average Full-Time Cost/Month	\$765.83	\$741.00	\$669.32	\$347.48

*For preschools, the median full-time cost per month was \$320.00 and the average full-time cost per month was \$312.50 in 2014. These fees are for licensed preschools and reflect fees for three days per week.

Figure #10*

Group Child Care Fees, 2014	Under 1	Toddler	30-60 Months	Out-of-School Care
Median Full-Time Cost/Month	\$1,100.00	\$990.00	\$787.00	\$375.00
Average Full-Time Cost/Month	\$1,138.09	\$1,038.93	\$827.41	\$382.48

* The fees for family and group child cares reflect the fees being reported by members of the YMCA Child Care Resource and Referral Program.



Section 9: Current Child Care Situation

DEMAND INDICATORS

Based on the child care operator survey, 59.4% of respondents reported typically receiving between 1 and 5 inquiries per week related to a child care placement. Another 25.0% of respondents reported typically receiving between 6 and 10 inquiries per week, while 15.6% of respondents reported typically receiving no inquiries per week. Based on a review of the types of child care, group (0 to 36 months) and out-of-school care typically received more inquiries per week related to a child care placement.

Regarding waitlists, 67.9% of child care operator survey respondents reported having less than 10 children on a waitlist for a child care placement, with the average being 3.2 children. Another 25.0% of respondents had between 25 and 200 children on a waitlist, while 7.1% of respondents did not keep waitlist information. As with inquiries for a child care placement, group (0 to 36 months) and out-of-school care typically had longer waitlists for a child care placement. It should be noted that some parents place their children on multiple waitlists, while others do not place their children on a waitlist as there is little likelihood of realizing a placement.

DEMAND INDICATORS

Regarding waiting periods, 48.3% of child care operator survey respondents reported a wait period of between 0 and 12 months for a child care placement. More specifically, 10.3% reported no wait period, 13.8% reported 1 to 3 months, 13.8% reported 4 to 6 months and 10.3% reported 7 to 12 months. Another 31.0% of respondents reported a wait period of between 13 and 24 months, while 20.7% of respondents reported that it was difficult to calculate and was variable depending on the care type. As with inquiries and waitlists, group (0 to 36 months) and out of-school care typically had longer waiting periods for a placement.



Section 10: Gap Analysis

GAP #1: AVAILABILITY OF CHILD CARE

This gap analysis is based on the results of the child care operator and parent surveys and input from the KIDS New West Child Care Action Team. Its purpose is to provide a summary of some of the major gaps and needs that will inform and be addressed by the new *Child Care Strategy*. It should be emphasized that other gaps and needs, many of a specific nature, have been identified and documented. These gaps and needs will also inform the development of the recommended actions in the strategy.

A typical family in Vancouver with a child in full-time care from the end of parental leave to the beginning of Kindergarten can expect to pay somewhere in the neighbourhood of \$50,000 for child care. By contrast, a four-year undergraduate arts degree at the University of British Columbia costs about \$31,000, including tuition, student fees and books.

Tara Carman, [Vancouver Sun](#), July 18, 2014

Despite the significant increase in licensed child care spaces in New Westminster, finding a suitable space still remains a challenge for many parents. In fact, 34.0% of parent survey respondents with a placement and 46.9% of parent survey respondents looking for a placement reported that availability was or is a challenge.

In reviewing the parent survey responses, the two care types which are most difficult to find a placement are infant/toddler (i.e., 0 to 36 months) and out-of-school care. Regarding the former, some parents reported delaying their return to work or paying far more than they had initially budgeted. As for out-of-school care, some parents reported that it was extremely difficult to find a placement at their child's school or in close proximity to it. As such, children were transported or walked to school, which raised concerns related to convenience and safety. The lack of this care type also raised concerns that some children, particularly 11 and 12 year olds, may be left unsupervised. These children are often referred to as latchkey kids.

Given the lack of the two cited care types, many parent survey respondents reported having to rely on family members or friends. In fact, 38.0% of respondents with a placement reported that their children received full-time or part-time care from a family member or friend. Some respondents reported that these types of care arrangements are typically less stable than more formal ones and that their children may be missing out on child development and social opportunities. Additionally, they reported that older family members providing such care may be overburdened or overwhelmed.



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GAP #2: COST OF CHILD CARE

The cost of child care continues to be an issue for many parents. Based on the 2008 parent survey, 15.0% of respondents reported that the cost of child care was a challenge in finding a placement. Based on the 2014 parent survey, 30.6% of respondents with a placement and 49.4% of respondents looking for a placement reported that cost was or is a challenge.

Regarding the percentage of household income which is allocated to meeting child care costs, the average for respondents was 15.5%; however, 17.3% of respondents allocated a quarter or more of their household income. This is a high percentage, especially when combined with the percentage of household income which is allocated to meeting housing related costs in New Westminster.

Regarding the Child Care Subsidy and Special Needs Supplement, which are provincial financial benefits that assist families with low to moderate incomes and those with children requiring extra support needs, 15.5% of respondents were in receipt of such benefits. Of those receiving benefits, 57.9% reported that they were insufficient to bridge the difference between their ability to pay and the actual cost of their child care arrangements.

GAP #3: FLEXIBILITY OF CHILD CARE

There are very few licensed child care facilities that offer flexible child care arrangements or non-traditional hours in New Westminster. Of the few that do, most offer extended hours (e.g., until 6:30 or 7:00 p.m.) on certain days of the week. In fact, 18.3% of parent survey respondents with a placement and 17.3% of parent survey respondents looking for a placement reported that inconvenient or inflexible hours were or are a challenge.

For parents who work evenings, nights, statutory holidays or weekends, or who require drop-in, emergency or part-time care, there are few, if any, options. As evidence, a number of parent survey respondents reported that they relied on informal care arrangements (e.g., family members or friends) to bridge times when licensed child care is not available. Some parents are also paying for full-time care when they require part-time care in order to secure a child care placement or are relying on babysitters or nannies as they provide greater flexibility.

The lack of flexible child care arrangements was frequently cited as a factor which limited a parent's ability to work, with a number of respondents reporting that they were unable to accept positions with non-traditional hours or work overtime. In fact, 37.3% of respondents reported that the lack of suitable child care limited their ability to work, with another 3.1% reporting that it limited their ability to find work. While these percentages are high, they are far lower than the percentages based on the 2008 parent survey – i.e., 51.0% and 10.0% respectively.



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GAP #4: CONVENIENCE OF CHILD CARE

There is a demand for child care which is located close to one's residence or local school. As evidence, 13.1% of parent survey respondents with a placement and 16.0% of parent survey respondents looking for placement reported that distance from their residence was or is a challenge. Additionally, 8.7% of respondents with a placement and 9.9% of respondents looking for a placement reported that distance from their child's school was or is a challenge.

Based on the open-ended survey responses, some respondents emphasized the importance of their children attending a child care facility in their neighbourhood, as it would enable them to get to know other families who live in the vicinity and would provide them with the opportunity to walk their children to and from the facility. A number of respondents emphasized the importance of child care being located in school facilities and on school grounds. For pre-school age children, respondents felt that it would facilitate an easier transition to Kindergarten and provide them with enhanced amenities, including access to gymnasiums, playgrounds and playing fields. For school age children, respondents felt that it would be more convenient and reduce the need to transport or walk children to school, including during inclement weather. Respondents with both pre-school and school age children noted that they could combine drop-offs and pick-ups and that siblings would have more contact with each other during the day.

In response to the question, "do you have any suggestions to improve access to or increase availability of child care," the second and third most cited responses were: "provide more out-of-school care spaces, particularly in schools," cited by 15.7% of respondents, and "increase child care spaces in school facilities and on school grounds," cited by 11.7% of respondents.





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GAP #5: QUALITY OF CHILD CARE

There were fewer concerns related to finding quality care than with regard to availability, cost and flexibility of care. Regardless, it still ranked fifth by those with a placement and seventh by those looking for a placement among the nine listed challenges, plus other. In fact, 12.7% of parent survey respondents with a placement and 4.9% of parent survey respondents looking for a placement reported that finding quality care was or is a challenge.

Quality is a subjective term; however, parent survey respondents, as part of the open ended responses, equated it to be licensed, having qualified staff, providing learning opportunities for children, and offering a safe and supportive environment. Of note, 96.4% of respondents felt that licensed or regulated child care was very important or important to them and 93.0% of respondents felt that child care staff having an Early Childhood Education certificate was very important or important to them.

There were very few concerns related to the

GAP #6: RESPONSIVENESS OF CHILD CARE

responsiveness of care with regard to meeting cultural traditions or special needs; however, there are likely underlying reasons to explain the low percentages of parent survey respondents who identified either as a challenge. First, given the difficulty in finding an affordable, quality child care space, other considerations, such as being able to meet cultural traditions, become secondary in importance. The increasingly diverse and multicultural composition of the city suggests that this should be more of a consideration and likely will be in the future. In 2011, immigrants comprised 33.4% of the population, with the top three source countries for recent immigrants being the Philippines, China and India. Second, given the relatively low percentages of parent survey respondents with special needs children, their challenges related to child care are likely significantly under-represented. Based on the child care operator survey, 28.1% of respondents reported that their staff were unable to adequately support children with special needs. Several operators also reported that their physical spaces were not well suited for children with special needs.

Based on a focus group with parents of children with extra support needs, participants reported that it was extremely difficult to find a placement, particularly for a child with special needs under 36 months. They also reported that child care environments can lead to sensory overload; that there is often little accommodation made to address special needs; and that too few care providers have an Early Childhood Education Certificate, a Special Needs Certificate, or relevant experience.



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GAP #7: ZONING & BUILDING CONSIDERATIONS

There is a lack of appropriately-zoned land and suitably-constructed buildings in which to locate new group child care facilities. Several child care operator survey respondents felt that the current maximum number of child care children (i.e., eight) permitted in Single-Detached Dwelling Districts should be increased to 16 or 20, as is the case in some other municipalities. They noted that this would meet the needs of parents who are looking for care closer to home and who are looking for smaller, less institutional settings.

Child care operator survey respondents, while appreciative of the permissive zoning related to child care in Commercial, Mixed-Use and Multi-Family Residential Districts, felt that there were few sites that can actually accommodate group child care facilities. Given the built-up and densely populated urban environment, especially in the Downtown and Uptown, meeting outdoor play space requirements was reported as being extremely difficult. Some operator survey respondents suggested that provincial licensing, which is responsible for regulating indoor and outdoor child care spaces, consider relaxing the requirements or being more flexible in their interpretation. They also suggested that the City create an inventory of suitably zoned sites for group child cares; that it incorporate suitably zoned sites within community and neighbourhood plans; and that it negotiate with developers for the provision of spaces suitable for child care.

Child care operator survey respondents expressed concern about the application of stringent Building Code requirements which make the use of existing buildings for child care purposes prohibitively expensive, particularly for infant/toddler care. Several respondents reported that the requirement to engage a Code consultant can cost up to \$5,000, which does not include the cost of any required upgrades. Additionally, the requirement to sprinker for infant/toddler group child care facilities can cost in excess of \$20,000 for a single detached dwelling and much more for a larger commercial or public assembly building.



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GAP #8: INFANT/TODDLER CHILD CARE

Despite the lack of and need for infant/toddler care (0 to 36 months) and efforts by the City to encourage this care type, many operators are reluctant to provide it. For some, they are not familiar with this age group or they have a history of providing a different care type. For others, they believe that it is more costly to provide than other care types or that it is far more difficult to develop. Regarding the latter, child care operator survey respondents reported that infant/toddler care requires far higher staff to child ratios (i.e., 1:4); increased indoor space (e.g., nap areas); and is subject to more stringent Building Code requirements (e.g., fire separations, sprinklers, etc.). Additionally, if combining care types, respondents reported that infant/toddler care requires a separate play area with developmentally appropriate equipment, which makes finding a suitable location, particularly related to outdoor play space, even more difficult.

More spaces for children under three years old are needed. Options only open up after your child turns 30 months.

Child care Parent Survey Respondent, 2014





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GAP #9: NON-PROFIT CHILD CARE

There have only been limited increases in the number of non-profit child care spaces since the 2008 child care operator survey. Non-profit child cares typically offer lower fees than corporate or franchise child cares. Of the 116 new or proposed non-profit child care spaces since the last survey, the vast majority (87 or 75.0%) were created as a direct result of the City or School District providing long-term, low-rate lease of space to non-profit operators. Another 76 new or proposed non-profit child care spaces will be relocated to new, purpose-built spaces as part of new schools.

There has been no net loss in non-profit child care spaces since the 2008 child care operator survey. Contributing factors include the creation of the City's Child Care Grant Program and the signing of a long-term licensing agreement between School District #40 and the Westminster Children's After School Society, which operates eight school age care programs within school facilities. Regarding the former, the program enables non-profit child care operators to apply for up to \$5,000 annually to address building deficiencies and to purchase needed equipment and furnishings in order to meet provincial licensing requirements.

It is difficult to find space in New Westminster. It would be great to see more opportunity for child care within new developments.

Child Care Operator Survey Respondent, 2014

Despite the fact that there has been no net loss of non-profit child care spaces, several non-profit operators continue to report unstable lease arrangements and/or less than ideal physical spaces in which to operate. These operators, based on the open-ended survey responses, suggested that the City and School District continue to pursue opportunities for child care in buildings and lands within their collective control and that the City negotiate with developers to provide purpose-built child care facilities within developments which would be leased to non-profit operators.



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GAP #10: STAFFING CONSIDERATIONS

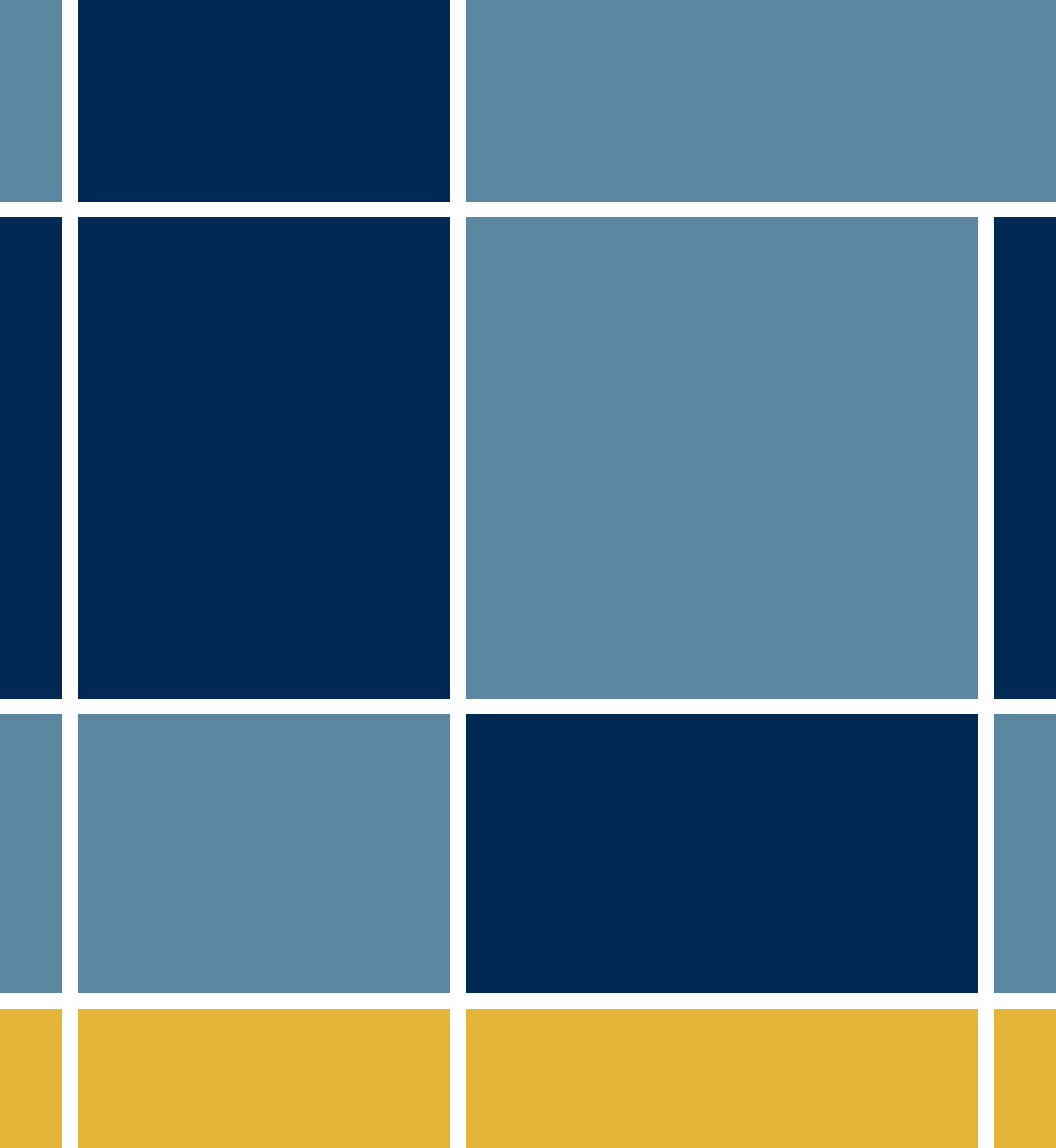
Despite fewer child care operator survey respondents expressing concern with regard to staffing, it is still an issue for over half of all respondents. Based on the 2008 operator survey, 90.0% of respondents reported that they had difficulty finding suitable substitutes and staff. Based on the 2014 operator survey, 55.9% of respondents reported that they had difficulty finding suitable substitutes and staff.

Regarding the most recent survey, many of the earlier cited concerns were still applicable. Respondents reported that it was difficult to find substitutes and staff who are willing to work part-time or split shifts. Additionally, three respondents reported that it was difficult to find experienced or qualified Early Childhood Educators willing to accept a 'reasonable' rate of remuneration and staff with special needs experience or training.

Regarding the profession, respondents reported that people are hesitant to enter the child care field given low wages and limited or no benefits. They also reported that child care workers are reluctant to take further education or training to advance their careers as it does not significantly improve their wage rates upon completion. Additionally, some respondents reported that graduates from Early Childhood Education are bypassing a career in child care for a more lucrative and respected one in teaching.

We are currently not filling any more child care spaces because we need to fill two full-time educator positions. Staff do not have adequate training and many are not looking for full-time work. Many graduates from ECE are going directly into BA programs and are transferring to SFU or UBC for Teaching. ECE is a jumping off point instead of a career.

Child Care Operator Survey Respondent, 2014



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